Westbrook School Committee

~ Finance Committee Meeting ~

Date: Thursday, March 19, 2026
Time: 5:00 PM
Location: Westbrook High School (Room 114), 125 Stroudwater St. (Hybrid via Zoom)
Video: https://vimeo.com/1175298314
Packet: No agenda was published for this meeting (checked westbrookschools.org, 2026-10-24).

Timestamps below are clickable [0:00]-style links — they jump straight to that moment in the video.

This summary highlights the meeting's key discussions and decisions, with direct quotes and timestamps for verification — it is not a substitute for watching the full meeting. *The full committee sat as the committee of the whole for this second consecutive FY27 cost-center budget review session; no votes were taken. For complete context, nuance, and anything not covered, watch the full video at the link above. (Produced by: WestbrookCurrents.com)*

Gifted & Talented, Finance Dept. & Superintendent's Office

Gifted & Talented: 100% State-Reimbursed, Essentially Flat [1:27]

Discussion Summary

Dr. O'Donnell reported the GT program is fully state-reimbursed (a year in arrears) and stays within the state's required 3–5% identification band (currently about 4%) using a blind, multi-person review process, not a budget-driven cap. The budget is essentially flat; member Erin Cavallaro asked whether the GT population is culturally/linguistically representative given the underlying assessments aren't, and was told it's "better than it's ever been."

Key Decisions

✓ No vote — budget review.

Action Items

None.

Finance Department & Office of the Superintendent [19:26]

Discussion Summary

Dr. Mazjanis described a small Finance team that recently moved to weekly accounts-payable processing and overhauled its business credit card program for better security/accountability. The Office of the Superintendent now consolidates three positions (Dr. Lancia, Dr. O'Donnell, Dr. Mazjanis). Notably, the district's budgeted contingency fund has been reduced to one-third of one percent of the total budget this year (down from half a percent). Dr. Flynn Ross noted municipal auditors typically recommend holding roughly 14% of an operating budget in contingency, and asked for historical contingency spend data, plus a consolidated total of all "negotiated contracts" dollars currently scattered across dozens of individual cost-center lines — staff agreed to compile both.

Key Decisions

✓ **No vote — budget review.**

Action Items
None.

Multilingual Program

581 Multilingual Learners, Third-Largest Population in Maine [35:12]

Discussion Summary
The district now serves 581 identified multilingual learners (25% of enrollment, up from 24% last year), representing 42 birth countries and 28 languages — the third-largest ML population in Maine. Presenting staff explicitly acknowledged, for the record, “the very real challenges many of our students and families have faced this year related to immigration enforcement and the presence of ICE in our broader community,” thanking staff and the community for the compassion shown “during these difficult times.” No new K-12 ML staffing is requested; the only new position districtwide is a half-time ML Pre-K teacher, driven by a new state language-screening requirement. 76% of MLs improved English proficiency on last year's ACCESS assessment, and 47 students exited services.

Key Decisions
✓ **No vote — budget review.**

Action Items
None.

Special Education

644 Students; New MaineCare Seed Budget Line; New Positions Requested [46:35]

Discussion Summary
The district serves 644 special education students (27% of enrollment). New staffing requests include an Ed Tech at Congin, relocating an unfilled Middle School Ed Tech to Saccarappa, a half-time Saccarappa speech therapist, and a new high school resource teacher to address a 39-student incoming ninth-grade cohort that would otherwise push caseloads past the legal cap. The Director of Special Services position remains vacant, covered by a retired former director on contract; sharing a director with a neighboring district was ruled out given Westbrook's special-education population is the highest in Cumberland County.

A newly explicit “MaineCare Seed” budget line (the state's 38% share of MaineCare billings for out-of-district placements, which can no longer be offset against the district's own MaineCare revenue as that population's cost has grown from $59,000 in 2020 to a projected $255,000 in 2025) prompted one member to remark it “broke my brain” — staff will prepare a white paper with a visual depiction. Out-of-district tuition costs are also rising about $92,000, driven by 2–6% rate increases at special-purpose private schools serving 14 Westbrook students.

Key Decisions
✓ **No vote — budget review.**

Action Items
None.

Elementary Schools: Canal, Congin & Saccarappa

Canal School: Supply Price Spikes, Dropping IXL, No New Staffing [01:20:03]

Discussion Summary

Principal Vicky Hebert (29th year at Canal, 15th as principal) reported a striking 41.8% annual transiency rate (53 students in, 35 out since August) and shared same-day vendor pricing showing sharp consumable cost increases for next year (pencils +43%, pens +83%, highlighters +116%, staples +100%, student scissors +301%) against a flat, already-cut per-student supply allocation — added to the committee's revisit list. The district is dropping IXL software districtwide (renewal pricing became “astronomical”) in favor of more hands-on, less screen-dependent instruction, a shift board members voiced enthusiastic support for, and is not continuing paid BAR behavioral-framework affiliation once its state grant funding ends (retaining the practices developed through it at no extra cost). Capital work underway includes ADA-compliant bathroom renovations and new mini-split air conditioning via a state renovation grant.

Key Decisions

✓ No vote — budget review.

Action Items

None.

Congin School: Stability Budget; Saccarappa: Largest Elementary, High Mobility [02:36:35]

Discussion Summary

Congin Principal Mark Bisson (3rd year) reported a stability-focused budget with one Title I teaching position moved to Saccarappa this year — a federally-required “maintenance of equity” reallocation, not an elimination. Playground mulch is being reduced to two-thirds of last year's catch-up order. Saccarappa Principal Alexa Jones reported the district's largest elementary enrollment (~400 students, 35% multilingual, 35% special education) and high mobility (79 students, 20% of enrollment, transferred in or out since August), running an active BAR-based intervention process serving about 100 students a year in formal math/literacy support. Both principals had several same-day budget-entry corrections identified and committed to during review.

Key Decisions

✓ No vote — budget review.

Action Items

None.

How this was made

This summary was produced from the meeting video (linked above, hosted on the City's Vimeo showcase). The audio was downloaded with Downie 4 and transcribed with speaker diarization using MacWhisper. Claude (Anthropic's AI) cross-checked names against the official School Committee roster, attributed speakers from context (introductions, roll-call order, direct address by the Chair) rather than the raw diarization labels alone, and drafted this summary and the quoted excerpts. Quotes are lightly cleaned of filler words/false starts but not reworded. Review tier: Not reviewed.

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